

DESIGNER

ALEXANDER MCQUEEN

One of the most important British designers of recent decades, Alexander McQueen reintroduced tailoring to fashion with his sharp suits and frock coats and brought new technology into couture. With a creativity that drove forward his quest for the new, he also reinvented the fashion show. "You've got to give them an extravaganza!" was his philosophy. At first unsettling, by the time of his untimely death aged 40, McQueen's shows had become theatrical events.

East End beginnings

Born in 1969, Lee Alexander McQueen was the son of a London cab driver and the youngest of six children growing up in Stratford, East London. Encouraged by his mother, a teacher, the young McQueen showed an early interest in fashion design, and at 16 enrolled as an apprentice cutter and tailor at Anderson and Sheppard, then tailors to HRH Prince of Wales. Legend has it that the teenage McQueen wrote obscenities in the linings of suits for the prince and other clients; what is certain is that he showed an extraordinary aptitude. After 18 months he had mastered the "forward" (a perfectly made test jacket), then learned to cut trousers at Gieves and Hawkes, and finally historical costumes at Angels and Bermans costumiers. Moving into high fashion, he became a cutter for the avant-garde designer, Koji Tatsuno and for Milan-based designer Romeo Gigli.

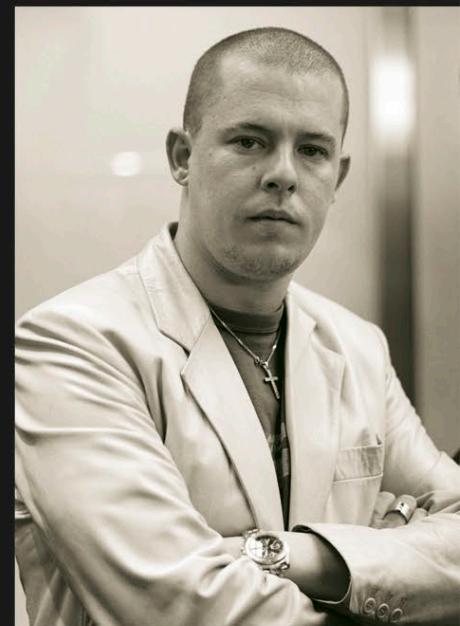
In spite of a single 'O' level in art, McQueen was accepted on the MA Fashion course at Central St Martins, London. His degree collection *Jack the Ripper Stalks His Victims*, featuring bustled jackets, papier-mâché appliqué and his own hair incorporated into linings, caught the attention of stylist Isabella Blow, who became McQueen's supporter and advocate. McQueen immediately began showing under his

own name. His bumsters at his second show *Nihilism* scandalized many, revealing the cleft in the models' buttocks, at the same time as elongating the torso and shortening the legs. This was a totally new idea, which launched a decade of low-slung, pelvis-hugging pants on the high street. His shows became must-see events, made on a tiny budget with a dedicated team. *The Birds* (Spring/Summer 1995), held in a disused warehouse was based on Hitchcock's eponymous film and, with the theme of road kill, featured tyre prints on dresses and corsetier Mr Pearl with his 46cm (18in) waist in McQueen womenswear. Iconoclastic and transgressive, it was a fashion moment that blew away the cobwebs.

History and nature

Skilled tailoring, revealed in the frock coats, suits, and all-in-ones that were signature McQueen, coupled with meticulous research, enabled the designer to realize his extraordinary ideas. Shows like *Highland Rape* (1995), based on historic border conflicts, were testimony to McQueen's fascination with history and his ability to make it modern, cutting tartan on the bias and updating body-moulding corsets. He also took inspiration from nature, using feathers, skin and bones, and even incorporating live falcons into his shows.

McQueen's tenure as head designer at Givenchy was not always a success, given its essentially genteel French signature, but he went on to find the creative freedom he craved at the Gucci Group. The designer was multi-layered in his talent and vision, and his later own name collections, *Horn of Plenty* in 2009, and his final show, *Plato's Atlantis* in 2010 raised questions about the future of the planet and man's careless approach. His label continues under the creative directorship of Sarah Burton, designer of the Duchess of Cambridge's wedding dress.



△ TAILOR AND CRAFTSMAN

McQueen was awarded British Designer of the Year four times. He was presented with a CBE and voted by CFDA (Council of Fashion Designers of America) International Designer of the Year in 2003.

◁ PLATO'S ATLANTIS

This dress from McQueen's final collection shows his skill in print and art and his love of the environment.



TIMELINE

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| <p>1985 Begins his apprenticeship at Anderson and Sheppard, Savile Row, London</p> | <p>1989 Employed as a cutter of historical costumes at Angels and Bermans, London</p> | <p>1990 Worked as a cutter for designer Romeo Gigli in Milan</p> | <p>1992 <i>Jack the Ripper</i> graduation collection at Central St Martin's College, London</p> | <p>1993 Bumster pants unveiled at <i>Nihilism</i> show</p> | <p>1996 & 97 UK designer of the year</p> | <p>◁ 1997 Brown ponyskin jacket with impala horns on shoulders from <i>It's a Jungle Out There</i></p> | <p>2001 ▷ Voss dress with black ostrich feathers</p> | <p>2003 International Designer of the Year awarded by CFDA. Presented with CBE by HRH The Queen</p> | <p>2009 <i>Horn of Plenty</i> show</p> | <p>2010 <i>Plato's Atlantis</i>—final collection focuses on future of the planet. McQueen's death</p> | <p>2011 <i>Savage Beauty</i> retrospective exhibition of McQueen's work at The Met, New York</p> |
| ○ 1985 | ○ 1990 | ○ 1995 | ○ 2000 | ○ 2005 | ○ 2010 | | | | | | |